

4.8 Option 6: Consuming the Rural Landscape – Leisure and Tourism

Consumption

Increasingly landscapes are undergoing a structural shift from production to consumption; in other words from primary production towards tourism and leisure. This shift affects rural landscapes of all types from the accessible rural-urban fringe to remote regions, increasingly, the locations of consumption are global and few areas remain untouched by leisure and tourism. This consumption puts pressure on often fragile rural landscapes, and represents a threat that requires careful management.

Reconciling the demands

Rural areas and landscapes can both benefit from increasing use for leisure and tourism, and can also be threatened by it. Reconciling the demands of consumers with the need to protect rural landscapes is a key challenge, which can be tackled in a wide variety of ways from preservation to ecotourism.

Global synoptic context

Key linkages

Places

Where are rural areas and what are they like?

People

Who lives in, and visits, rural areas?

Power

Who manages the threats facing rural areas?

Suggested teaching and learning

Mapping the distribution of different rural areas in the UK or USA

Using photographs of UK and world rural areas and contrasting them in terms of degree of leisure and tourism use

Examining the role of an organisation such as the US National Parks Service

1 The growth of leisure and tourism landscapes

Enquiry question: *What is the relationship between the growth of leisure and tourism and rural landscape use?*

What students need to learn	Suggested teaching and learning
■ The rise of leisure and tourism and the spread of the pleasure periphery for active and passive pursuits.	■ Developing awareness of the global growth in leisure and tourism and investigating the reasons for it, including globalisation.
■ The range of rural landscapes, from urban fringe to wilderness, sought for leisure and tourism activities.	■ Examining the wide range of different uses that leisure and tourism activities make of rural landscapes and the recent growth in such activities.

■ The attitudes of different groups of people involved in this relationship: governments, intergovernmental agencies, businesses, pressure groups, communities and individuals.	■ Research into the different groups of people involved who have different values and attitudes to rural landscape use.
■ How different leisure and tourism activities in rural landscapes may lead to conflicts.	■ Developing an awareness that different activities in the same area may lead to conflicts in the use of rural landscapes.

2 The significance and fragility of rural landscapes

Enquiry question: *What is the significance of some rural landscapes used for leisure and tourism?*

What students need to learn	Suggested teaching and learning
■ The physical significance and ecological value of some rural landscapes.	■ Developing an awareness of the ecological and physical value and fragility.
■ How rural settlements may be classed as fragile landscapes.	■ Researching the complex linkages within naturally functioning natural ecosystems in a wilderness and human made systems at the urban fringe or in rural settlements.
■ The degree of threat to rural landscapes by using models such as the carrying capacity model and the resilience model.	■ Being able to apply models — such as the carrying capacity model or resilience model — and assessing their usefulness.
■ The use of qualitative and quantitative environmental quality measures, and their usefulness, for example in designating protected areas such as National Parks.	■ Investigating the range of qualitative and quantitative methods; and the criteria used in measuring the quality of rural environments and their usefulness.

3 Impact on rural landscapes

Enquiry question: *What impact does leisure and tourism have on rural landscapes?*

What students need to learn	Suggested teaching and learning
■ The range of negative impacts leisure and tourism has on rural landscapes, such as trampling, pollution, erosion, habitat disturbance.	■ Investigating the wide range of negative impacts that leisure and tourism activities can have on rural landscapes.
■ The range of positive impacts leisure and tourism has on rural landscapes, such as wildlife conservation, river restoration, conservation of heritage sites.	■ Investigating the wide range of positive impacts that leisure and tourism activities can have on rural landscapes.
■ Ways in which impacts can change over time as the nature and level of use varies.	■ Researching the impacts that may change over time and the reasons for such changes.
■ The threats and opportunities posed in areas of differing economic development.	■ Developing awareness that as the pleasure periphery expands and disposable income increases globally, tourism hotspots are found in all economic groupings, so increasing numbers of areas experience both positive and negative impacts.

4 Rural landscape management issues

Enquiry question: *How can rural landscapes used for leisure and tourism be managed?*

What students need to learn	Suggested teaching and learning
■ Whether rural landscapes should be managed or not.	■ Investigating the arguments for and against the management of rural landscapes.

■ The range of different management strategies including preservation, conservation, stewardship, sustainable management and the growth of ecotourism.	■ Developing an awareness that there are a range of management options and that there are advantages and disadvantages of each including the concept of mitigation.
■ The attitudes and strategies of different groups (residents, government, pressure groups, business/industry) and the conflicts that can exist between them.	■ Developing an awareness about the nature of conflict between different landscape users and managers and why conflict has arisen.
■ The effectiveness of different approaches to managing rural environments.	■ Examining a range of different management strategies as applied to different locations.

Suggested fieldwork opportunities for consuming the rural landscape – leisure and tourism

Local fieldwork ■ An in-depth fieldstudy of tourism types and its impacts along a continuum from the rural urban fringe to a wildscape. ■ A study of a national park to identify conflicts and management methods ■ Research into the fragility of a rural landscape, and the threats facing it, used for recreation.	Residential and long-haul fieldwork ■ Many areas, both in Europe and further afield could be studied in depth. ■ Examples include the Alps, the coastal resorts of France and Spain (which often inter-mingle with protected areas), as well as the National Parks of the USA.
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